



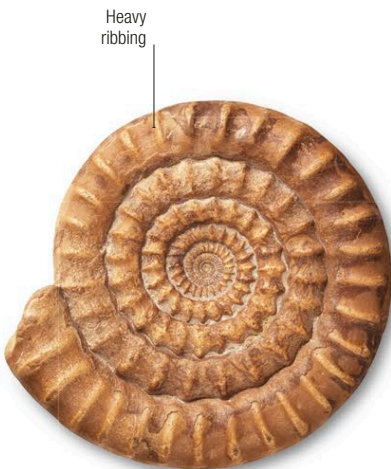
Ammolite

△ Ammonite fossils in an unusual grouping

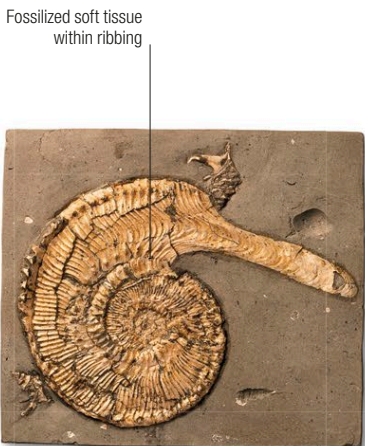
Ammolite is the lining of the shell from the ammonite, a mollusc that became extinct roughly 66 million years ago, around the same time as the dinosaurs. Its iridescent colours cross the spectrum, but green and red are most common, with gold or purple being rarer. It is found in many parts of the world, but the best examples come from Alberta, Canada, where it is mined. The Native Americans of Alberta, the Blackfoot people, know it as Inskin, or Buffalo Stone, and believed that it could attract buffalo near enough for them to be hunted.

Specification

Chemical name Aragonite polymorph | **Formula** CaCO_3
Colours All spectral colours – red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, violet | **Structure** Orthorhombic | **Hardness** 3.5–4 | **SG** 2.75–2.85 | **RI** 1.52–1.68 | **Lustre** Vitreous
Locations Canada, USA



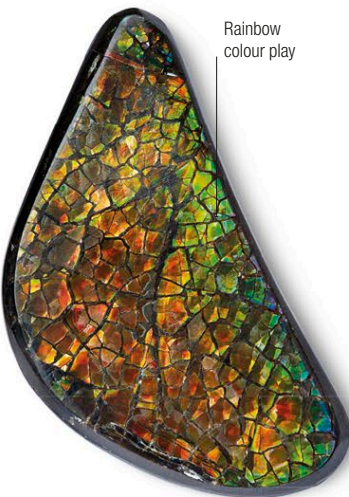
Coiled ammonite | **Rough** | This fossil of the ammonite *Dactyliosarus* shows classic coiling and ribbing. It is from the Jurassic Period, up to 200 million years ago.



Unusually preserved specimen | **Rough** | This fossil ammonite *Kosmoceras duncani* was found in Jurassic Oxford Clay in England; it shows some fossilized soft tissue.



Sawn ammonite | **Cut** | This fossil *Oxynotoceras* ammonite has been sawn and polished to reveal its inner chambers, infilled with calcite.



Ammolite | **Cut** | A section of the fossilized outer shell of an ammonite, this ammolite gem weighs 23.70 carats with a maximum length of 33mm (1¼ in).



Snakestone | **Carved** | Following the legend of St Hilda turning snakes to stone, modern lapidaries have started carving snakes' heads onto ammonites, as here.

Snake or ram

Animal links

Ammonite is named for its similarity in appearance to a ram's horn. The 1st-century CE Roman writer and natural philosopher Pliny the Elder called the fossilized molluscs *Ammonis cornua* ("horns of Ammon"), after the Egyptian god Ammon (Amun), who was usually represented with ram's horns. In medieval Europe, the fossils were called snakestones or serpentstones and were believed to be petrified snakes, the work of saints such as St Patrick or St Hilda of Whitby.



Egyptian god Ammon as a ram's head This stela (stone slab) would have served as a gravestone.